"ChatGPT, Review This Message to My Prof" Investigating Students' Use of AI for Online Communication in Academic Settings

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Abstract

Students communicate with diverse recipients across multiple text-based channels in academic settings. As students increasingly use AI to compose and revise messages, AI introduces a new element into the communication process that existing communication frameworks have not fully accounted for. To understand why and how students use AI for online communication and how they perceive its impact, we conducted two-phase interviews with 12 students: first, participants mapped their online communication into recipient-channel groups (e.g., "instructor over school email") and indicated their level of AI use for each group; then, they described selected groups in depth. In this poster, we present preliminary findings on when students use AI based on 110 recipient-channel groups across 12 participants, as well as factors behind students' decisions to use AI based on six interviews. We identified 31 recipient-channel contexts and found that students' AI use was shaped by channel-related factors, recipient type, and message characteristics.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in collaborative and social computing**.

Keywords

AI-Mediated Communication, Online Communication, Communication Channels, Academic Relationships

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1 Introduction

In academic settings, students communicate with diverse recipients, including professors, advisors, peers, and administrators, across multiple text-based channels, such as email, course-management systems, and direct messaging applications. Existing communication theory provides a framework for understanding the elements of this process. Classic models of communication, including Shannon and Weaver's model, describe communication as a process involving core elements such as the sender, receiver, message, and channel [6]. Media Multiplexity Theory extends this account by describing how the social relationship between sender and receiver is reflected in the channels they use to communicate [4]. These theories have been used to study communication in academic settings [1–3, 5].

Increasingly, students are relying on AI to mediate online communication, using it to compose or enhance the messages they send. While elements such as receiver, relationship, message, and channel have been studied in depth in communication research, the advent of generative AI has introduced a new element in the communication process whose role is not yet well understood.

This study aimed to understand why and how students use AI for online communication in academic settings, and how they perceive its impact. For this poster, we focus specifically on when and why students use AI for communication.

To address this, we conducted two-phase interviews with 12 students. In the first phase, participants mapped their online communication in academic settings as recipient-channel group (e.g., "instructor over school email") and indicated their level of AI use for each, ranging from never using AI to always using AI for communication. In the second phase, participants explained the backgrounds and motivations behind their AI use or non-use for two to four selected recipient-channel groups in greater depth.

Our analysis of the first phase revealed diverse recipient-channel contexts and patterns of AI use across these contexts. For the second phase, six participants were selected for preliminary analysis to examine why students use or do not use AI for online communication. This analysis revealed decision factors behind participants' use of AI including channel, recipient, and message characteristics.

2 Method

A two-phase interview study centered on participants' prior cases was conducted to investigate students' use of AI in their online communication in academic settings. This study was approved by the Institutional Review Board (IRB) at our institution.

Participants were recruited through institution channels at multiple universities in North America, supplemented by network and snowball sampling to increase diversity in location and disciplinary background. Eligibility was restricted to students aged 18 years or older who reported proficiency in university-level English, so that AI use was not primarily a tool for language or cultural mitigation. Participants were also required to have used an AI tool



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Table 1: Participant information, including their gender, age, and major, and inclusion in the preliminary Phase 2 analysis.

ID	Gender	Age	Major	Program Level	Included in Preliminary Analysis
P1	Female	18-24	Natural Science	Graduate	No
P2	Female	18-24	Social Science	Undergraduate	Yes
P3	Female	18-24	Social Science	Undergraduate	No
P4	Male	18-24	Arts/Humanities	Undergraduate	Yes
P5	Female	25-34	Arts/Humanities	Undergraduate	No
P6	Male	25-34	Engineering	Graduate	No
P7	Male	25-34	Engineering	Graduate	Yes
P8	Female	25-34	Engineering	Graduate	Yes
P9	Female	18-24	Business	Undergraduate	Yes
P10	Female	18-24	Business	Undergraduate	No
P11	Male	25-34	Business	Undergraduate	Yes
P12	Female	35-44	Business	Graduate	No

to help write messages in an academic setting within the past six months. The final sample comprised twelve participants spanning Natural Science, Social Science, Arts and Humanities, Engineering, and Business. Participant information is shown in Table 1.

Each participant completed a 60-minute two-phase interview conducted over video conferencing, audio-recorded with consent and transcribed in full. In Phase 1, participants reviewed online messages they had sent across academic relationships over the previous six months. On a shared digital whiteboard, they created a sticky-note memo for each recipient-channel group (e.g., "instructor over school email"). To measure social relationships, we collected closeness and relational importance. These were chosen among the four relational factors used to define social ties in academic settings in Clark-Gordon [3]. For each memo, participants rated their closeness with recipients from very distant to very close (very distant, distant, close, very close) and relational importance between important and not important, and were invited to indicate intermediate positions where appropriate. They then placed each recipient-channel group memo on a spectrum from "never use AI" to "always use AI."

In Phase 2, the interviewer selected two to four recipient-channel groups per participant for in-depth walkthrough. The selection ensured a range of AI-use frequencies, including at least one recipient-channel group where the participant had never used AI, and that the participant had a full record of the communication history or strong recollection. For the selected recipient-channel group, participants described the message context, why and how AI was used, and how they imagined that continued AI use might affect their perception of themselves and of their relationship with the recipient.

Phase 1 produced 110 recipient-channel groups across the twelve participants (4 to 20 per participant), which were thematically analyzed and consolidated into 31 recipient-channel contexts that recur across the sample. For Phase 2, transcripts from six out of twelve participants (P2, P4, P7, P8, P9, and P11) were analyzed for preliminary findings of decision factors behind the use of AI. These six were selected to balance gender and different disciplinary backgrounds across the subsample.

Coding proceeded through an iterative cycle, where the first author conducted sentence-level open coding on each transcript, and all authors met to review the codes to consolidate themes and direct the next round of analysis. The cycle continued until a typology of participants' AI-use orientations and perceptions stabilized.

3 Findings

3.1 Overview of Recipient-Channel Contexts

3.1.1 Recipient-Channel Contexts. We identified 31 recipient-channel contexts, indicated as a colored, outlined cells in Figure 1. These contexts are defined based on three elements: channel, recipient, and relationship.

Channel was categorized into four types: 1) social media channels including Instagram, Line, Whatsapp, Discord, and iMessage (Social Media); 2) collaboration platforms set by the institution including Slack and Microsoft Teams (Institution Channels); 3) learning management systems such as Canvas (LMS); 4) and Email.

Recipient was categorized into four types: 1) individual peer recipients (Peer); 2) a group of peer recipients (Peer Group); 3) recipients involved in participants' instruction, such as faculty, instructors, and teaching assistants (Teaching Team); and 4) recipients who support participants administratively or logistically, such as administrators, staff, and project stakeholders (Admin/Project Support).

Relationship contained two components: closeness and relational importance. While four relationship types can emerge (close and important, close and not important, distant and important, distant and not important) for each recipient type, Teaching Team did not include close and not important relationships, and Admin/Project Support did not include any close relationships.

3.1.2 AI-Use in Recipient-Channel Contexts. Figure 2 maps AI-use of 110 recipient-channel groups across 31 recipient-channel contexts. Each recipient-channel context displays values in the format N1/N2, where N1 represents the number of groups in which AI assistance was used and N2 represents the total number of groups for that recipient-channel context.

To facilitate visual interpretation, cells are color-coded according to the distribution of AI-assisted groups. Gray indicates contexts with two or fewer total groups. Dark blue indicates contexts with three or more total groups in which AI was used in none of them (0%). Light blue indicates contexts in which AI was used in half or fewer of the total groups (equal to or less than 50%). Light red indicates contexts in which AI was used in more than half of the total groups (greater than 50%). Dark red indicates contexts in which AI was used in all recorded groups (100%).

Two general patterns emerged. First, Teaching Team and Admin/Project Support recipient types were mostly communicated to through Institution Channels, LMS, and Email, and showed high AI use, with 62 of 80 recipient-channel groups (77.5%) reporting AI use. In particular, email was the only channel that produced contexts in which participants sent messages using AI all the time, as observed in Important Teaching Team and Important Admin/Project Support. Email was also perceived as the primary channel for communication with institutional and professional recipients rather than peers. P8 stated: *"I don't actually use Gmail to chat to communicate with my peers. So usually someone more official, like an academic advisor and also professor."*

Second, Peer and Peer Group recipient types were mostly communicated to through Social Media and showed low AI use, with only 6 of 30 recipient-channel groups (20%) reporting AI use. Social media was the only channel where there were recipient-channel contexts with no AI use, observed in close and important Peers, and distant and important Peer Group.

Recipient	Relationship		Channel			
			Social Media	Institution	LMS	Email
Peer	Close	Important	■	■	■	■
	Close	Not Important	■			
	Distant	Important	■	■		■
	Distant	Not Important				■
Peer Group	Close	Important	■	■	■	■
	Close	Not Important	■			
	Distant	Important	■	■	■	■
	Distant	Not Important	■	■		
Teaching Team	Close	Important		■		■
	Distant	Important		■	■	■
	Distant	Not Important			■	■
Admin/Project Support	Distant	Important		■		■
	Distant	Not Important		■		■

Figure 1: Observed recipient-channel contexts reported by 12 participants. Filled cells indicate that at least one instance of the corresponding combination was reported.

Recipient	Relationship		Channel			
			Social Media	Institution	LMS	Email
Peer	Close	Important	3/11	1/1	1/1	1/3
	Close	Not Important	0/3			
	Distant	Important	0/1	1/1		2/3
	Distant	Not Important				2/4
Peer Group	Close	Important	3/8	2/2	1/1	1/3
	Close	Not Important	0/1			
	Distant	Important	0/4	2/4	2/2	2/2
	Distant	Not Important	0/2	1/1		
Teaching Team	Close	Important		1/1		3/3
	Distant	Important		4/5	6/7	9/9
	Distant	Not Important			4/7	3/5
Admin/Project Support	Distant	Important		3/4		6/6
	Distant	Not Important		1/1		3/4
Total			**6/30**	**16/20**	**14/18**	**32/42**

Figure 2: AI use across recipient-channel contexts, reported as N_1/N_2 within each cell, where N_1 is the number of recipient-channel groups in which participants reported using AI and N_2 is the total number of recipient-channel groups for that combination.

3.2 Decision Factors Behind the Use of AI

3.2.1 *Channel-Related Factors.*

Channel's Perceived Professionalism. When the channel is perceived as professional, participants used AI more. Particularly, participants described email as carrying an expectation of professional register and cited this as a reason for AI use. P11 stated: *"It's more so with the emails itself, the emails are in general, just a professional way of conversing with someone. So in that sense is where I would use AI."* Participants also described LMS as a professional context. P2 noted: *"For Canvas and Gmail [...] I want to sound more professional instead of casual."*

In contrast, when the channel is perceived as casual, participants used AI less. Participants consistently described social media as a casual channel and cited this as a reason for not using AI. P9 noted: *"WhatsApp seems like more casual talking. That could be a factor of*

why I choose not to use AI." P7 similarly noted: *"But then if I'm just messaging them on, let's say, iMessage [...] I wouldn't use AI for that. I would be much more comfortable sending in my own text."*

Channel's Message Control Features. Participants cited reduced control over sent messages, such as post-send editing and unsending, as a factor that increased the perceived stakes of composition and their likelihood of using AI. When describing their use of AI when emailing professors, P4 explained: *"I can't unsend something that I've already sent [through email]. So it is a bit more serious. I triple, quadruple check my emails."*

Participants described greater post-send control as a factor that reduced their use of AI. Unlike email and LMS, participants noted that Slack and Social Media supports post-send editing. P8 stated: *"But for Slack and WhatsApp, you can edit [your message], so you don't have to be that worried about that sometimes. So the channel and the platform also contribute to your decision making [to use AI]."*

3.2.2 Recipient Types.

Peer and Peer Group. For these recipient types, participants felt comfortable communicating and therefore reduced their use of AI. P2 explained, *"Whenever I send messages to my friends, I don't feel like I need to sound a certain way. So I can just send whatever."* Similarly, P7 noted that, *"I'm a bit comfortable writing messages to this person [...] I don't use AI for informal communication."*

Yet, one participant (P8) cared about how they appeared to their peers and thus used AI. When explaining their messaging to Peers, P8 explained that they, *"Use AI to check the way I use my words. [...] I do check grammar and I check the tone. I always ask AI about it."* P8 additionally explained that for Peer Group, the group size was considered: *"For this group chat, I do sometimes use AI to make sure of my writing because the target audience is very large. I don't want to, you know, feel silly."*

Teaching Team and Admin/Project Support. For these recipient types, participants used AI to create a professional impression. P11, when explaining their emails to the Teaching Team and Admin/Project Support, stated that, *"The only times I use AI is when I need it to be super professional [...] I guess the root cause is [because] I don't have that confidence to say one hundred percent that I can create these professional emails."* This may or may not be impacted by relational closeness. P8 stated directly: *"Basically the more distant a person is with me, [the more] I will try to use AI,"* when talking about messaging the Teaching Team. On the other hand, P7 noted that they wanted to seem professional regardless of relational closeness as long as it falls within the Teaching Team: *"I'm writing an email to [...] a professor. I would still use AI regardless of my [closeness] with them."*

Professional impression management using AI included grammar and spelling check, structure, and tone. When discussing messaging to Admin/Project Support, P4 mentioned that they, *"Care to write a good email with good grammar."* Similarly, P9 also described asking AI when emailing the Teaching Team to, *"Double check the grammar and spelling [...] make sure it was a good format for a professor to read."* P2 used AI to check the tone when emailing the Teaching Team: *"Yeah, I think tone because I wanted it to seem more professional."*

3.2.3 Message Characteristics.

Message content impacted participants' use of AI. Participants explained that they use AI when the message contains high-stakes content. When describing their use of AI in an email to a professor, P9 explained that they, *"Didn't want it to leave a bad impression if I was asking for an extension."* P2 similarly explained that they used AI when they, *"Forgot to submit an assignment and then I wanted to email the professor [to ask] if I could possibly submit it late for partial marks."*

At the same time, the message length also impacted participants' decision to use AI. For example, P2 stated that, *"When I'm sending an email, it's like a longer, larger message. So I would like to use AI to review it."* While high-stakes and lengthy messages were usually conveyed through emails, long messages made participants use AI even when it was sent through channels other than email. P7 described a Slack exchange with a peer: *"My message was very long [and] I had a lot of information to share. So I type it out in my own way to AI and I [said], hey, look, you know, just correct this."*

As such, participants weighed message content against message length when deciding whether to use AI. For instance, P2 did not use AI for a high-stakes email because the message was brief, explaining: *"I emailed my [professor] regarding my previous final grade. I didn't use AI here [because] it was a short and straightforward question."*

4 Discussion and Conclusion

Communication theories identify receiver, message, and channel as key elements of the communication process, while Media Multiplexity Theory highlights how channel use reflects the social relationship between sender and receiver. Our study shows that students' AI use is shaped not by any single element, but by all of these elements together: the recipient, their relationship with the recipient, the channel, and the message. Rather than relying on a single factor, students consider these elements in relation to one another when deciding whether to use AI. In the full analysis, we aim to provide a fuller account of students' AI use in online communication, including how they use AI and how they perceive its impact. This broader understanding can contribute theoretically by clarifying where AI sits in the communication process, and how it may be influenced by and influence the broader set of elements and processes through which communication unfolds.

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